
1st Place: *Sunset on Rosio Beach*

by Kyle Mawhiney

He leaned back into her arms, watching the setting sun, the powdery sand caressing them both with the warmth of the beach. He smiled at the slight tightening of the arms around him, reaching back with one hand to touch her cheek. The waters lapped at their feet, the reddish deep idly threatening what remained of their small meal. He looked out across the sandy expanse, studying the shadows cast over the scattered debris by the dying light. Long, bluing shadows touched over by the mist hanging red all about them. He closed his eyes for a moment, enjoying the feeling of bodily warmth against his back, trying to capture this subtle feeling of security and happiness. He felt her lips press against the top of his head as her arms tightened around him again. He glanced over at the carefully sliced meats on the plate beside them, watching the play of red and orange pleasantly discolor the food. Turning away from the remnants of their dinner he curled further into her arms, tilting his head back to kiss her. He watched her smile in the light of emerging stars, sitting up a bit more to wrap his arms tightly around her. He lay holding her as the air cooled, the mist in the air turning to the lightest rain. She pushed against his shoulder, wanting him to sit up, and rose to sit facing him. She took his hand quietly, gliding to her feet, pulling him up with her. He glanced over the debris strewn beach as she led him over the cooling sands becoming damp with the falling mist. He slipped his arm around her waist, resting his head on her shoulder.

She stopped for a moment, looking down at one of the hundreds of bodies scattered over the beach, one from which the choicest flesh had been cut for their dinner. He took the moment she bent down to collect some bauble from the slain comrade to wipe some of the red rain trickling over them from his face. She turned back to him, tucking her prize into her pocket.

"Talk to me, lover. Talk to me in the old French."

He laughed faintly, slipping his arm back around her waist, "You always ask me to talk to you, but you never understand what I say. Why do you ask this of me? You'll only ask me to talk to you again in English so you can know what I have said. I'll talk to you, but later. Let's not disturb the dead we have known, and the dead we have slain, with a language gone dead before them."

She nodded and bent his head to her shoulder as they took to walking again, "Few died today. Look how light the rain is."

2nd Place: *A Faith in Love*

by Kyle Mawhiney

She stared blindly at the blank stretch of wall before her, her small chisel and mallet dangling loosely from her fingers. She ached to act, to continue her creation on the walls of her lonely loft. She closed her eyes, letting the ever-present angst of her life keep her from her art. She thought for a moment of the man writing downstairs, the man who had made her into the warmthless creature she was now. With all his protests of love he never came up to the loft to see her, except to tell her when she had a visitor come. She was in a way grateful for it, she had no want to hurt him. Seeing her as she was now, listless--kept even from her beloved sculpting by her loneliness, would hurt him. She started a bit as her hollow loft rang with a knock at her door. Quickly she wiped away her bloody tears and darted to the door, forcing a smile as she opened it.

"Oh, hello, Salvadore." she wondered a bit at the curious joy in her maker's eyes. Who had come now that he was so happy for it?

"What are you doing, Xanthe?"

She glanced at her maker curiously, shrugging slightly, "I was just working a little. Why?"

He smiled brightly, "Would you like to go out tonight?"

"Well I do have things I should be doing." she half turned back to her prison loft.

"Oh, can't it wait tonight?" he suddenly scooped her from her feet into his cold arms, her hands quickly clasping behind his neck to steady herself.

She blinked in confusion, weakly gesturing back to her cell, a small smile lighting her face, "I suppose... What is this, Salvadore?"

He shrugged, turning to carry her down the stairs, "I just wanted to."

She hesitated a bit, her disheveled appearance suddenly striking her, "Oh, but, Salvadore, I can't go out like this."

Her maker continued down the stairs happily, "Why not?"

"Just look at me. I'm a terrible mess."

"So?"

She relented in amazement, letting him carry her from the house and place her gently in the car. She wondered in silence as he drove uptown, past wealthier and wealthier streets, coming to a stop before a palatial hotel. He turned to her, his smile hopeful. He tugged a strip of cloth from his pocket.

"Turn a moment, won't you?"

She obeyed, bewildered, letting him blindfold her. The thick cloth silenced the world to her preternatural ears as well as blinding her inhuman eyes. After a moment the door beside her opened and she was lifted from her seat and carried into the hotel. They paused once or twice before she felt the nauseating disorientation of an elevator. Her maker took a few steps after the long ride up the building before delivering her into another pair of arms with a soft kiss to her cheek.

"Don't take off the blindfold, please? Just let them do whatever they will."

She nodded obediently and let herself be carried off to be rested in a comfortable chair. After a few moments a pair of decidedly feminine hands undressed her and led her to a bath where they washed and massaged her. After the bath she was led to a bed where she lay as her hair was washed and styled while her body was delicately rubbed with pleasantly fragrant oils. She let her thoughts come back to her through her confusion and fear, banishing the unpleasant under the wonderful wash of her exquisite treatment. She caught herself singing softly and laughed to herself as she fell silent. She was then carefully dressed in silks, her feet sheathed in velvet slippers. She let herself be led down corridors and left standing, her confusion returning for a brief second before she felt her makers cold hands at the back of her neck freeing her from his cloth imposed deprivation. She kept her eyes closed for a moment, letting the delicate chamber music lilt within her before letting in the sights to accompany the sound. She looked first down at her dress, the pearly silk delighting her. She looked up at the white bedecked room, all the pearly white she so adored, highlighted with burgundy here and again, lit by a single crystal chandelier. She rushed to the wall window, overcome by the clouded night and the twinkling lights of the city so far below. She stepped away from the window, holding the diaphanous shawl about her shoulders slightly away from herself with her fingertips as she turned in graceful circles, as much to take in the beauty of the scene as to give her maker the joy of watching her. She finally rested her eyes on the man who had pro-

vided this unexpectedly delightful scene. He wore a finely cut eighteenth century suit in burgundy velvet and white silk. She approached him with slow grace, taking his hand softly in both of hers, looking into his eyes.

"Oh, Salvatore... It's all so precious."

Her maker smiled slowly, raising her fingers to his lips, "It's all for you, Xanthe."

She glanced around, taking in the beauty again, her voice nearly breaking, "Oh, Salvatore..."

He brought her close to him, her head turning to rest on his cold breast, his chill arms encircling her. She slipped her left hand into his right, inviting him to dance. He freed his hand only long enough to clap once, changing the music to something even more choice, before gently sweeping her up in dance. She reveled in his motion, the music, the room spinning wondrously around them. She laughed as she felt the too familiar loneliness gone from her. She looked again into her maker's eyes, sharing in his joy. What more could she ever want? He had made her so happy tonight. He who had killed her so long ago and stolen her away from life. She felt a painful resurgence of her loneliness. She would never have true joys, meaningful joys because of him. She would never know the true touch of a man. She would never know the happiness of motherhood. She would never know the pride of a family. She stopped the dance, looking up at her maker with teary eyes, slipping from his grasp and slowly sinking to her knees. He knelt quickly beside her, looking at her with unsure eyes.

"Oh, Salvatore... Why? Why have you done this?"

"Because I love you, Xanthe. Because I want you to love me. I want us to be happy together."

She looked down at her hands, splayed across each other palms up, "You know that can never be, Salvatore. You made me."

He shook his head helplessly, "Can't you forgive me, Xanthe?"

She shook her head slowly, "You know I cannot, Salvatore. You know I cannot because you don't regret what you've done to me. I know why you took me, I know you could not have done otherwise, but I cannot forgive you. I'm sorry, Salvatore, but you knew when you did it that I could never love you."

She watched her bloody tears fall onto her hands and spill over onto her dress, staining the pristine white with the ever-present scarlet of her existence. Her maker took her hands in his, leading her slowly to her feet. He stepped over to a table beside the window, taking one of the two wine glasses in his fingers, looking into the red filling the glass with other than wine.

"Xanthe..."

"I'm sorry, Salvatore. But you knew it would be this way when you made me. I know you could not have borne it if you hadn't taken me but I cannot forgive you. And you know you cannot regret what you have done to me."

Her maker nodded, stepping back over to her, "Then I will try no more. I'm sorry for the advances I've made. I thought that somehow I could break the rules. I thought that somehow I could get you to love me though none other of our kind has managed."

She looked down at the glass in her maker's hands, "Oh, Salvatore, you know it's the way of our kind. I know that some day I too will take someone and try what you have tried with me. We are too needing of love for it to be otherwise."

She turned her eyes away from her maker to her slippers and walked slowly to the door, leaving him staring into the crimson in his hands. She heard the shattering of glass as she closed the door.

Runner-up: Witch's Ball

by Barbara Ann Flowerday

Gary was at the bottom of the downward slope of middle age. One could say from observing his conduct that he must be suffering from a mid-life crisis, but anyone who knew him, knew that his life had always been symptomatic of that particular malady.

Gary was moderately successful by current American standards. As a mid-level executive in a Fortune 500 company he was able to indulge himself in status-toys, and keep his family comfortable in upper middle-class splendor.

Gary was really not a bad guy, as his co-workers and cronies would attest to: but if you were to ask his wife and family, they might give you a different story. For Gary suffers from chronic self-centeredness and while a good provider, could not provide wife nor children with the one thing they needed most: a loving husband and father.

Currently, Gary was on the make. For the past several weeks, Gary had developed an itch that needed scratching and was on a campaign to get laid.

* * *

It was Thursday evening about 8:00. Gary had grabbed a quick dinner out and was now milling about a Barnes and Noble crosstown from his home. He had shaved and changed his shirt at the office, splashing on expensive cologne. To his credit, he was handsome in an aging collegic sort of way.

He paused for a moment in the Home Repair section and thought of what was plaguing him. He knew his wife was waiting home for him with her spreading hips and constant demands: becoming less and less anything he wanted to screw.

Values, vows, and morals had never been a deterrent for Gary, and so he had been on friendly terms with several female coworkers and this had satisfied him up till now. But that was like sleeping with the enemy. For his bed partners were either his rivals in the quest for corporate glory or they wanted something from him: favors, an introduction, a hand up the ladder...

It was tiring having to watch your back all the time for fear of committing professional suicide. And besides that, he had enough with hard-bitten career women with their slick hairdos, tailored mock-male suits, their leather attache cases and day planners, cell phones and beepers, but most of all their, efficient, passionless sex.

Shit. The last one had actually taken a call on her cell phone as he was doing her on his desk ! She had even gone so far as to put a carefully manicured finger to her lips letting him know that she expected him to be quiet.

All this had brought him to his new course of action or rather field of play. From the inadvertent advice of his college-bound daughter, he had learned that the hot meeting spots had evolved from the singles bars of the 80's into coffee shops and bookstores of the 90's.

For the past two Thursdays, he had frequented a Starbucks, but met with no success. How much coffee can you sip, and for how long, before it becomes obvious you're on the make, and looking like a dick besides ? And although he was loathe to admit it, the conversations going on around him somewhat intimidated him. He was afraid of being drawn in and then found out; having noth-

ing to say. Because without being conscious of it, Gary was a very limited person. His whole world consisted of the 8th floor of his office building and his sole interest lay in sports. Period.

So tonight he found himself browsing the shelves and perusing the women. He just wanted to fuck. And someone interesting. Someone different.

He rounded a bookshelf and found her. A creature unlike any he'd ever known in his mediocre existence.

She stood tall, perhaps as tall as his 6ft 3 frame; but slender and willowy. Due to their relative height and his coming upon her so quickly their eyes had locked and held. It was like free falling into a void. The bookstore was gone. Her unwavering gaze held him and bore holes into his soul. All that existed for a moment were those eyes; an odd deep blue that made him think immediately of glacial winter nights.

Uncomfortable, he broke free finally and was compelled to examine the rest of her.

Starting from the top, a wealth of glossy black curls were piled casually high on her head with escaping stray tendrils that curled enticingly at the nape of her long neck.

Her skin was an unearthly white that set off to perfection the dark brows, those unnerving blue eyes, and a full mouth with lips as dark and bruised as concord grapes. The white skin continued on flawlessly down her throat and over her breasts where it met in startling contrast the black velvet of her dress.

The dress was simple and above the knee but spoke volumes on a small neat waist and the graceful curve of her hips. Long long legs sheathed in sheer black hose: his eyes followed down the length of them till he came to the delectable cracks between her toes where they disappeared, shod in pointy-toe stiletto heels of black.

Sweet Jesus. Already a dull ache in his groin, and for a moment he imagined those long legs wrapped around him. Immediately a stabbing pain sliced viciously through his head. He wavered.

Long long tapered fingers settled briefly on his arm demanding attention, and then when he was looking into those eyes again, she spoke.

" Are you looking for someone ? "

From the ambiguous inflection of her voice he couldn't tell whether she was mocking him, propositioning him or being helpful. His mind suddenly so clouded - he felt his thoughts swimming through something viscous and oily. Usually so glib and confident, he followed now where once he led. All he could think to get out was an exceptionally feeble " I'm looking for a book... "

Christ. In the middle of a bookstore. No shit. Only the testosterone propelled thoughts seemed to swim freely and he chastised himself for such a lame opening; but was still vain enough though to think he had a chance.

One of those long beautiful fingers came out again and gently tapped the spine of a black cloth-bound book.

" I find these rather interesting... " she said

The hand dropped away and he could now see that the book was entitled Witchcraft.

He had the presence of mind to look around and finally found the sign directly behind her smooth white shoulder that helpfully proclaimed this section to be Occult/Religion.

His brain cramp seemed to be easing now and his confidence and/or cockiness returning. " Yes, I enjoy anything supernatural, metaphysical... " (this last word he had picked up from one of his fruitless Starbucks evenings)

She was smiling at him openly now. " Oh well, if that's the case perhaps you would meet me

here one evening, I'm sure you would find it gratifying. "

Had he imagined it, or had she placed special emphasis on the " gratifying " ?

Whatever the case she was gone. Past him in a smooth fragrant moment. Somehow from her hand to his, he now held a creamy black embossed invitation; or card really, that simply read :

Bring your appetites

Friday evenings

Midnight til Dawn

Next Friday evening found him in his Armani, elbows on a quiet bar downtown, nursing a scotch and studying the card.

At quarter to twelve he climbed into his Lincoln more unnerved than he ought to be and drove to the address listed discreetly on the card.

The ride brought him to one of those grand and quiet neighborhoods in the better part of the city. Genteel homes built at the turn of the century on grand scale; mansions if you will, with meticulously manicured lawns, circular drives, and lots of old, old money.

He found number 77 and parked next to several sleek big-money cars. He followed a cobblestone walk lit by wrought iron torches holding aloft guttering orange flames. They produced a black oily smoke he could discern even against the dark night sky.

He paused on the portico noticing that there was a bell-pull instead of a doorbell. He had to admit he was intimidated: the first brief encounter, the intriguing card...he had no idea what the night held in store.

Christ. All he wanted was a simple lay.

Whoa boy. let's reconnoiter. A beautiful, obviously wealthy, mysterious woman: what more could he want ?

He chastised himself for standing there acting like a schoolboy. Disdaining the bell-pull he rapped sharply on the door with his knuckles.

He had a long wait. He used the wait to look around, but could see nothing.

Two sets of french doors opened onto the colonnade aside from the front door. They gave away nothing. Hung with a dark heavy fabric, no small particle of light escaped. Not a glimpse was to be had of the interior or it's inhabitants. Rather the glass only mockingly reflected back the exterior: the dancing orange flames of the torches lining the walk and himself, hands cupped around his eyes and peering in like an idiot. He saw the latter and pulled away quickly feeling ridiculous again.

About to turn away and give up, he paused for a moment and listened again. There! Faint strains of a melodious music and the gentle rise and fall of women's voices.

Someone was in there. He felt like the forgotten guest; standing in the dark, alone, and unadmitted.

He chuckled to himself. No, more like an old tomcat in heat sniffing around that no one wanted in.

He strode back to the door and almost rapped on some poor guy's forehead before he realized the door was now open and someone was waiting there ready to show him in.

No warm bath of light. The dark inside was equal to the darkness out. The only thing Gary could clearly makeout was the man standing beside the door, dressed in white from head to toe sim-

ply and unobtrusively.

In the gloom, but for the whites of the man's eyes, it would have appeared as only a shirt and pair of pants standing there.

Gary hurriedly fished the woman's card from his breast pocket to present as an introduction. The white man recognizing it, tiredly replied " No need " and waved him in.

He was led down a hallway whose contours were all but obscured by lack of illumination to the point that it was almost like walking into a void. The blackness held a different quality here. Not just absence of light; it was rich, and dark with something indiscernible.

They came to a stop and almost hesitantly, the white man opened a heavy set of double doors, motioning him forward. Gary stepped in. It was like stumbling into an enchanted garden of nodding face-flowers and animated hand-leaves. Truly, all that could be seen was their white skin luminescent against inky blackness.

Faces turned towards them and then away as they continued on with their conversations. Hands rose and fell like birds as they gracefully gesticulated to the rhythm of their words.

Finally one of them beckoned to the white man and he led Gary forward. Then, as if on command, little flames leapt to life. They did little to dispel the gloom however; rather, it only allowed the dark to detach itself but slightly from the black figures.

Slowly it washed from their faces and slid down their shoulders, spilled from their laps traveling down the folds of their gowns to puddle at their feet.

He recalled now in the bookstore the odd whiteness of her skin. Here their skin was positively luminous, and cascades of heavy black hair. Women. They were flowers of the same family, but each within the confines of their similarities were strikingly different.

Some angelic: with cupid bow lips and doe eyes. Some were exotic with slanting eyes and chiseled cheeks. And a few were even rather plain, with coarser features; but not distasteful.

And their dress!

Trailing trains and capes and veils, high bustles and billowing hoop-skirts, and all manner of enchanting bodices enhancing mounded breasts...it was intoxicating. (He knew he was staring like a dumb ape. He felt as though he'd stumbled upon Mecca.) Silks, velvets, brocades, and all manner of sheer gauzy fabrics that draped , constrained, and teased their magnificent figures - and every stitch of it in black.

Most of them were seated on massive throne-like chairs; high-backed and claw-footed with intricate but grotesquely rendered carvings of writhing forms and vicious animals, all richly upholstered.

There were fainting couches and divans of similar design each draped with a reclining figure, and in the center of the room was an immense table ringed with yet more chairs of the like. The table alone could easily accommodate 50 and was set as if for a grand banquet with heavy crystal and gleaming cutlery. Yet not a morsel, not a crumb of food was present.

Large free-standing candelabrams provided murky pools of light here and there that strangely enough the figures seemed to shun. But he could see well enough: Gary guessed he was in the presence of about 80 women.

Not one of them paid him the slightest attention.

Still at his side, Gary could now better see his companion, White Man, as he was coming to think of him. He seemed almost transparent, like the shell of a man left behind as a molting bug.

He appeared young; but sucked dry, and although heavily muscled , he was stooped and

exhibited extreme fatigue. He must have seen the reflection of himself in Gary's eyes for he reached out and touched his arm, " Welcome " he said " I could use the company - it's a goddamn nest of spiders...Then he abruptly turned and left, closing the big doors behind him.

Gary was left alone with them. He was only too aware of a queasy sense of unease growing steadily in the pit of his stomach but he pushed it down. He chose to hold onto his high hopes and began searching among them for " his woman, " the one from the bookstore.

She was nowhere to be seen, and yet looking at them now, he didn't know if he was capable of recognizing her. As remarkable as she had been, she could have been anyone of these women now. He found that he was quite incapable of distinguishing amongst them.

At any rate, no one came forward. No one spoke to him. Instead they continued on their conversations around him and over him but never taking their eyes from him.

He chuckled nervously: he wondered was it possible to be the center of attention and ignored all in the same moment ?

Then, suddenly, as if it were time, they all rose in concert. Not one of them stood under 6 foot tall. Gary drew in a sharp breath. They beckoned to him.

From there on out it was a blur, a kaleidoscope, shifting sand obscuring, and quicksand drawing him in; but only too enjoyable. They had entertained him richly. Exotic and delicious dishes of every description had appeared before him. They ate not a crumb. They plied him with drink: goblets of absinthe, bitter and yellow. He had reached for one of their frothing chalices and they had laughingly pushed him away. Other than that, they denied him nothing. He remembered the sweet smell of hashish and pulling on the pipe. And he remembered their cold watching eyes and avid smiles. Lovely, lovely bare exposed breasts peeked here and there from dropped bodices like stars twinkling against a black sky. And so many red-lipped white-teethed smiles flashing around him...

At what point did the alarm bells start going off in Gary's head ? Was it when he found it harder and harder to string together two words ? Was it when his limbs no longer responded to his commands ? Or was it when he had a hard time feeling his extremities; all except the motherfuckin' one that landed him here in the first place ?

Or, maybe it was the pity he read in White Man's eyes the last time he shuffled away at their bidding...

Ever increasing waves of high-pitched feminine laughter ebbed and flowed in his ears crashing up against and obliterating his sensibilities.

" Now you see what happens when you walk around led by your dick... "

Who said that ?!

What ?!

Suddenly he wanted to puke. He wanted to scream no. He wanted to crawl home to the safe bosom of his boring wife. He wanted to cry. But none of that happened.

They set upon him with terrible, sanguinous red lips, ripping lacquered talons, and the horrid vice-like grip of long, long legs.